



Lesson 5: Create Your Personal Brand

What You're Doing Today

You already have direction (Lesson 2), a portfolio site skeleton (Lesson 3), and a bio + first case study (Lesson 4). Today you're building a **Brand Kit** — a small, simple set of visual and voice choices that make your portfolio instantly recognizable as *yours*. By the end of class, you'll have colors, fonts, a simple mark, and a tone of voice, all in one Canva board.

Why It Matters

Recruiters, teachers, and future collaborators look at a lot of portfolios. The ones that stick in someone's memory usually aren't the ones with the most content — they're the ones that feel **consistent**. Same colors, same fonts, same voice, every time they show up. That consistency is a brand, and it's something you can build in one class period without any professional design training.

Important reframe: A brand is NOT a logo. A brand is a *system of repeated choices*. A logo (or in your case, a simple mark) is just one small piece of it.

The Four Brand Elements

1. Color Palette (2–3 colors)

Pick: - **One dominant color** — used the most (backgrounds, headers). - **One accent color** — used for buttons, links, highlights. - **(Optional) one neutral** — usually white, black, or gray, for backgrounds/text.

Keep it to 2–3 total. More than that starts to look cluttered and unplanned.

2. Font Pairing (2 fonts, max)

- **One heading font** — bolder, more distinctive, used for titles/names.
- **One body font** — clean and easy to read in longer paragraphs.

Pick two fonts that look *different enough* to create contrast (e.g., a bold geometric heading font with a simple readable body font), but not so different they clash in mood.

3. A Simple Mark

This is not a professional logo. It's one small, repeatable visual — pick ONE: - Your initials inside a simple shape (circle, square, hexagon). - Your name, always typed in your heading font, in your dominant color. - One simple icon connected to your interest area (e.g., a small compass for someone into exploration/travel tech).

One shape. One or two colors. Done in under 10 minutes.

4. Tone of Voice (3 adjectives)

Three words that describe how you sound when you write — in your bio, your case studies, everywhere. Examples: "curious, precise, encouraging" or "bold, direct, playful." Check: does your Lesson 4 bio actually sound like these words? If not, that's useful to notice.

A Quick Note on Color Contrast (Accessibility)

Not everyone sees color the same way, and some people have low vision. A basic rule that professional designers follow (called WCAG — Web Content Accessibility Guidelines):

Text needs to stand out clearly from its background. Dark text on a light background, or light text on a dark background, usually works. Two "medium brightness" colors together (like a medium orange on white, or light gray on white) are often too hard to read.

You don't need to memorize numbers today — just remember: **if you have to squint to read your own sample text, so will everyone else.** Save your brightest/lightest accent color for small things like buttons or borders, not paragraphs of text.

Worked Example: Jordan R.'s Brand Kit

Jordan is interested in game design and wants their portfolio to feel focused and calm but still energetic.

- **Colors:** Deep navy `#1B3A4B` (dominant — header, nav bar, footer), warm amber `#F2A93B` (accent — buttons, links, highlights), off-white `#F5F5F0` (background/neutral).
- **Fonts:** Heading — a bold, geometric sans-serif (e.g., Poppins Bold). Body — a clean, readable sans-serif (e.g., Inter Regular).
- **Mark:** A navy circle with "JR" centered in white, in the heading font.
- **Tone of voice:** "curious, precise, encouraging."

Notice: navy text on the off-white background is easy to read. Amber is only ever used for small elements (buttons, small accents) — never for paragraph text — because it's harder to read at small sizes on a light background.

Step-by-Step Canva Activity

1. Open Canva and start a blank design (any size — 1080×1080 works well).
2. Add three rectangles side by side. Use the color picker's hex code field to enter your 2–3 chosen colors. Label each one with its hex code and where you'll use it.
3. Add a text box with your heading font — type your name or a sample title.
4. Add a second text box with your body font — type one sample sentence.

5. Build your mark: add a circle or shape in your dominant color, then add your initials or icon on top in your accent/neutral color. Keep it centered and simple.
6. Add one line of text with your three tone-of-voice adjectives.
7. Step back and look at the whole board — every piece should feel like it belongs together.
8. Rename your Canva design "[Your Name] — Brand Kit" and set sharing so your instructor can view it.

Key Terms

- **Brand:** A consistent, recognizable system of visual and verbal choices that represents you.
- **Color palette:** The specific set of colors (with hex codes) you use everywhere.
- **Hex code:** A six-character code (like `#1B3A4B`) that names an exact color so it looks the same everywhere it's used.
- **Font pairing:** Two fonts — one for headings, one for body text — chosen to work well together.
- **Mark:** A simple, repeatable visual symbol (like initials in a shape) — a lightweight stand-in for a logo.
- **Tone of voice:** The specific personality your writing has, described in a few adjectives.
- **Contrast (accessibility):** How clearly text stands out from its background so it's readable for everyone, including people with low vision.

Knowledge Checks

1. True or False: A brand is the same thing as a logo.
2. Why is it usually better to limit your palette to 2–3 colors instead of 5 or 6?
3. What's the difference between a "heading font" and a "body font," and why do you need both to look somewhat different from each other?
4. Give one reason a bright, light accent color might be a poor choice for paragraph text.
5. What are the three adjectives in your own tone-of-voice descriptor, and how do they connect to your Lesson 2 niche or Lesson 4 bio?

Reflection Prompts

1. Which of your three brand colors was hardest to choose, and why?
2. Look back at your Lesson 4 bio. Does its wording actually match your tone-of-voice adjectives? What's one sentence you might rewrite later so it matches better?
3. If a stranger saw only your color palette and mark (no words at all), what might they guess about you? Is that the impression you want?

Submission Instructions

1. In Canva, set your Brand Kit design to shareable (view access) and copy the link.
2. Complete the Worksheet for this lesson (color table, font pairing with reasoning, tone-of-voice line, mark description, and consistency checklist).
3. Submit both the Canva link and the completed Worksheet through your class's submission method by the end of the session.